Not Dragon at the Gate but Research Partner

The Reference Archivist as Mediator

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In a keynote address given to the Spring 2000 Midwest Archives Conference meeting (hereafter Sawyer Seminar), Francis Blouin set out the founding principles for this seminar as a dialogue between historians and other scholars, and the archivists who maintain documentary collections for research use. As became clear from the seminar conversations that ensued, the concept of "archive" has a broader range of definitions than those of us who are practitioners in the field might have imagined. What also became clear was that the archivist's role in the maintenance of this documentation was not at all clear.

Many of the participants, citing the derivation of the term *archives* "from the Latin *archivuum,* 'residence of the magistrate,'" appeared to conflate past and present accessibility of archival documentation. For many, the concept of archives was a purely theoretical one: "In cultural theory, 'the archive' is endowed with a capital "A," is figurative, and leads elsewhere. It may represent neither material site nor a set of documents. Rather it may serve as a strong metaphor for any corpus of selective forgettings and collections," wrote one participant. The singular lack of interest in the realities of current archival practice and theory was demonstrated by the lack of attendance by these scholars at later seminar sessions on archival topics.

Most disturbing, however, were statements such as "Foucault [in his *Archaeology of Knowledge]* provocatively warned [that] the archive is neither the sum of all texts that a culture preserves nor those institutions that allow for that record and preservation."[1] It is a useful warning to current archivists that such a perception still exists. We are only too aware that, through selection and other factors affecting the availability of texts for collection, we house only a fraction of history's documents. Archivists also assume, perhaps naively, that our researchers have always subjected these texts to scrutiny and skepticism as to their meanings and origins.

At the same time, Blouin and others challenged archivists with the "need to become more self-aware of our role as mediators . . . between records creators and records repositories, between archives and users, between conceptions of the past and extant documentation."[2]

While I absolutely believe that the archivist has agency in the research process, I would characterize it instead as a consultancy, and myself as a partner in re-search.[3] I will explain this more fully later in this essay.

First, however, I have found that the fluidity of the concept of archives, among those who use archival documents but do not claim archivist as a profession, is quite disconcerting. I believe a brief digression about the purpose of keeping archives is in order. I hope to show that much of what characterizes what I consider to be an archives also highlights the contributions that I, as a reference archivist, bring to the research partnership: my knowledge of the breadth of the collections, the nature of recordkeeping, and the contextual information that gives documents their "greater than the sum of their parts" meaning.

The Repeatable Experiment

Elizabeth Yakel, in her article "Thinking Inside and Outside the Boxes: Archival Reference Services at the Close of Page 37 → the Twentieth Century," has put it most succinctly: "The enduring value of archives is partly that certain records can be continuing sources of knowledge."[4] While this may no longer be the scholar's concept of archives, it is the foundation of all that the archivist works toward: the collection and description of documents to be universally available for study by anyone. The corollary most applicable to the reference archivist is that these documents should not be changed by their use but remain available for future generations to study, to use to gain new insights, and to make further comparisons.

While some very real criticisms can be leveled at the varied processes of collecting over time, there are two distinct concepts here: whether every documentary collection is necessarily incomplete, and whether anything can be an archive.

Blouin notes that “instead of directing the process of uncovering the past through available fragments, the archive is subordinated as one contested element in a variety of tangible and nontangible elements that help construct a sense, an image, a theory, or a representation of a particular past.”[5] So, are we all archivists of our own archives? That does cast a different light on the guidelines for archival use: respect original order, remove nothing from the repository, maintain an emphasis on preservation and provenance. An archival repository attempts to guarantee that all researchers' experience with a collection of documents will begin with the same available set—regardless of which collections they select or what conclusions they may draw from each collection. Other archives are, in our terms, ephemeral or inconsistent, or harder to access, or subject to interpretation by a donor still in control of the collection. All facts may be facts, all social memory useful, and all understandings valid. But, if I can't follow a set of citations and examine what was used to come to the conclusions, then there will always be just one interpretation of that fact or understanding. Archivists strive to make just the opposite possible.

Indeed, there is an implied responsibility of the archivist to guarantee, or at least be able to explain or appraise, the evidential value of documents retained by an archives. There is no question that many experiences remain undocumented. For the past several decades it has been a major aim of archivists, many educated at the same time as the new social historian, to seek out this more ephemeral documentation and enrich their collections with a broader view of society. But, once the documents were located (or even created, in the case of the growing body of oral history collections), they became part of the archives. As such, their keepers were charged with the dual responsibilities of making them widely known and available—and guaranteeing that they remained the way they were found, unaltered and identical for each researcher.

A postmodernist approach might decree that all meanings derived from our collections are valid and useful. But the archivist still feels a responsibility to impart the original constructs—old meanings of words or contextual realities that obtained when the documents were created—for the interested researcher.

This brings us back to the concept of mediation, and the role of the reference archivist. I should clarify, first, that there are many ways in which archivists mediate between documentation and researcher. Deciding how to focus a collection, what to collect, which portions of a collection to preserve, and arranging and describing these materials for public use all inherently shape the user's perceptions of their research topic. In this essay, however, I will focus on the mediated experience of the reference interaction. Whether this happens face to face or in a digital environment, attitudes, intentions, and awareness can entirely change what the researcher discovers and whether he or she is successful in locating all the archival sources that will be useful for the project undertaken.

Dragon at the Gate?

I am very aware that archivists and researchers often play adversarial roles. Some of this comes from misconceptions about who makes access decisions and how, and a distaste for what seem like too many, or too capricious, sets of rules. Some of it also comes from a sense of ownership, not shared with the researcher, which I have observed in too many of my colleagues. When I was at the MIT Archives, the archivist told us of her predecessor, who had carefully collected the files from an institute-wide committee on academic values. But, when the faculty member who deposited those records came back to refer to them several months later, he was told, “Oh no. You can't see those now. They're in the *archives.*” Case closed. Needless to say, much of our challenge in administering the archives consisted of undoing this impression and encouraging use.

One of the most important ways in which the reference archivist can mediate the experience of a researcher in the archives is to continue what one of my colleagues calls “the conversation.”[6] This is not a particularly startling concept, but it ensures that the mutually educational Page 38 → process (“what are you finding?”/ “what does this say?”) continues unimpeded.

The first step in mediation is to ensure that what can sometimes be an antagonistic relationship instead begins to

build a research team. If the communication is bad, it often ensures that the rest of the research enterprise never even happens. Researchers come in to pick up a quick answer and then discover that it will be a long search process, and they must wait while items are retrieved, one at a time, and they can't copy things themselves, and half the collections are in offsite storage. Empowerment is actually a very helpful way to look at reference. Not wanting to look incompetent is as important a research motivator as creating research products such as getting an A on a paper or meeting a report deadline. We see it on researchers' faces as they walk in the door, we hear it in their defensive comments over the phone and e-mail.

Archival researchers often begin their interactions with “I'm new here,” or “I don't know anything,” or “This is going to sound stupid.”[7] Clearly the first task of the archivist is not going to be defining provenance or copyright or scope and content notes. Before any other interaction can take place the archivist must make the researcher feel welcome and attended to, and that, yes, it is very possible to navigate this place and get some good and useful information for his or her project. Oh, and could you lock up all your belongings and put away your pen and we may ask you to wear gloves and come back later for your copies. It is a difficult balancing act for the reference archivist to simultaneously communicate the desirability of the researcher's presence and also the necessity of obeying rules regarding access and handling to ensure the preservation of what the researcher wants to use.

This is where archivists play an educational role. I like to stress the treasure hunt aspect of archival research with the media and with the public: it can be a tough job, but there really is treasure at the end of the hunt. And we as reference archivists are here to show you where and how to dig so that the process doesn't seem so mystifying and impossible.

This brings us back to empowerment. Archivists' pride, too, is on the line. Some of my proudest moments have been when an unhappy or disgruntled researcher feels heard and ends up having a productive time in my reading room. By assisting researchers and managing a good outcome, rather than by using our authority to point out only what they are doing incorrectly, archivists win as do the researchers. Saving face sounds like a selfish motivation, but it's often the reality of these interactions. The trick is to make it work for the partnership, not against it.

When I was the reference archivist at MIT, I conducted a reference interview with a visiting historian of science. He arrived asking to see what sources we had in the history of nuclear medicine. Immediately my mind began racing to the answer I thought he wanted—and coming up blank because MIT doesn't have a medical school. I felt ignorant about the nature of the topic—not an uncommon occurrence in that job—but I took a breath and said, “You know, I really don't know anything about nuclear medicine. Can you tell me a bit about it and we can see where that might lead us?” It turned out he was exploring the medical applications of research in physics, and in that field we had an abundance of collections. The researcher spent several days using personal and institute records in the archives. Braving my own sense of embarrassment to learn from him allowed me to be of much greater use in providing information about the history and organizational structure of my institution.

Reference Archivist Roles

On a typical day we play more roles than Alec Guinness in the film *Kind Hearts and Coronets*. Every day we play the roles of tour guide, teacher, consultant, salesperson, matchmaker—and certainly mediator. Each role uses different aspects of our knowledge as reference specialists and archivists to connect the wide variety of researchers interested in using our collections, the various finding aids and tools archivists construct to make the materials accessible—and the actual documents themselves.

The first step is outreach: this can be as complicated as an interactive online exhibit featuring primary source material, or as simple as making sure the archives is represented in the brochure rack at the library. The general principle is the same: archivists try never to assume that their publics understand the value of archival materials, how these materials can be useful in their professional or personal lives, or how to discover what we have and how to use it. In my position as reference archivist at an academic archives, I placed a high priority on reaching out to students and faculty, to whom I offered introductions that could be titled “What's an Archives and What'll It Get You?”[8]I also worked with administrators whose noncurrent records are held in the library. Much of this work

could be summed up as the antithesis of the example I Page 39 → gave above: “Oh yes. Please use those records now that they're in the archives. Case opened!” We don't wait for researchers to find us. At every opportunity, we insert ourselves into the research process with reminders of the richness of our holdings and research assistance we provide.

Much of the educational work of the reference archivist does come in the form of deliberate instruction, such as orientation sessions, and online tutorials such as Yale University's.[9] Just as often, though, this education is the less formal one-on-one orientation, in-house or via email, in using and interpreting primary sources. This skill is surprisingly rarely taught in any academic curriculum, so the researcher often finds him- or herself with a box of raw material and no experience in placing it within a context or evaluating its contemporary meaning. The reference archivist comes to recognize a variety of signals from a crooked finger, a tentative “excuse me?” or “hey you,” all of which indicate this confusion. Our job is to help them puzzle through the item, ask the larger questions, assist in reading the ancient handwriting, explain an outdated form, help place the correspondent within the organization's hierarchy at the time of the document's creation, or suggest related reading. Often, for example, researchers don't make the connection between a faculty member as private researcher and the records they may have created in an administrative role. Helping researchers to make these connections and to think in a different way is part of the ongoing education that takes place in archival reading rooms every day. More importantly, we convey to researchers the skills to make these connections on their own the next time they encounter a puzzling bit of what Blouin calls the “available fragments of history.”

Yakel also stresses the translator role of the archivist and adds that translators must understand both languages or cultures to function well.[10] Researchers approach us with questions phrased in the language of their own discipline. We rephrase the question, adding information about the nature of our records, as well as instruction in how to understand the language of our search engine, the cataloging and filing rules of the Online Computer Library Center (OCLC) database, Library of Congress (LC) descriptions, and the structure of our individual online catalogs. Indeed, LC subject headings and “neutral” descriptive language are often arcane, value laden, and hopelessly behind the times. New “natural language” keyword searches are better, as they aren't dependent on the LC authority over various iterations—but the natural language is that of the cataloguer, nonetheless. Regardless, these standardized descriptive conventions are how our collections are to be understood. It is the reference archivist's job to translate the language and impart the skills needed to use the research tools.

Clearly, another significant role of the reference archivist is in training researchers to think like archivists.[11] This is not to say that we train them to be archivists. It means that the concept of understanding a bureaucracy in order to request the records from the appropriate office, or to think about how an individual organized their files in order to know which box to request, is a foreign one to our users. This is a perfect example of the archivist as translator; archives have a language all their own that shows no immediate signs of changing. “Scope and content note,” “provenance,” “EAD”—even “finding aid”—usually draws a blank (“Finding what?” I'm often asked). We not only translate the lingo of the archivist, we also convey the value of the concepts communicated by these terms: how would you express the merits of a scope and content note? And, more importantly, how would you, in just a sentence or two, sell the researcher on not skipping past this useful information to head straight for the tantalizing box list (which they do every day)?

The most traditional archival finding aid, for example, is based on a strictly hierarchical structure. Organizations exist in hierarchies, and the records of their officers are arranged that way. Even the finding aids themselves run—at least until the Encoded Archival Description (EAD) format bled the lines between physical and intellectual order—on an implacable hierarchy of series, box, folder. The series are described in the front matter, then lists of their contents follow. Series are in order but broken across boxes. Boxes are listed at the beginning but not with each folder. Once the concept is explained, it is easy to follow, but until then even the most sophisticated researcher, unfamiliar with archives, will approach us and ask us to explain how this “book” (finding aid) works. Online finding aids follow the same structure, and we are beginning to think of general instructions to orient researchers to the most effective use of these new widely available tools. Wading through this structure and translating as I go often does remind me of being a tour guide. If the past is a foreign country, then educating researchers about using archives can feel like conducting a Berlitz course.

In fact, in archival reference workshops I begin with a brainstorming session where we write down “What Every Researcher Should Know.” This results in a list of what we wish researchers entering our reading rooms, or Page 40 → accessing us by electronic means, to understand about how archives work. In addition to the usual procedural rules, there are the assumptions that archivists make: about the hierarchical structure, about respecting original order, about the fact that most collections are organized as their creator or author intended, not rearranged for some future research use. These concepts, too, must be translated or explained—and we don't even all agree on them: witness ongoing archival discussions of the continued value of provenance!

Access restrictions also require the mediation and intervention of the archivist—to explain and to handle the process of gaining access. Consider, for example, many researchers' experiences in the Soviet Union, before and after the fall of the communist state, where bribes might be required to facilitate access, files might be withheld capriciously, and records might be sold for money to heat buildings. Blouin noted, “it is the extreme case of Soviet Russia that exposes a process that is part and parcel of all archival institutions that struggle with the challenges of bulk, historical preconceptions, and specific institutional responsibilities.”[12] Most such restrictions are the result of government regulations or the wishes of individual donors on giving their private property to an archival repository. They are the conditions of the gift, not the wish of the repository.

The Society of American Archivists' Code of Ethics[13] specifies that archivists weigh equally their organizational responsibilities, or the needs of the donor, with the needs of researchers for ready access. It falls to the reference archivist to standardize the procedure of requesting access, negotiate the request in as timely a way as possible, and communicate to the researcher that this is neither a capricious nor unusual practice.

An equally intermediary role delineated by Yakel is that of the knowledge broker. The archivist often crosses boundaries in ways that other individuals in organizations or academia don't tend to: they are the true inter-disciplinarians, for they not only know many areas of study, as do librarians, but they are also familiar with knowledge needs, and political realities, throughout the parent organization. Yakel argues that archivists must take their place “as an equal and active participant with users in the knowledge creation process.”[14] This echoes my belief in the consultant nature of the reference archivist's work.

I originally developed my archival reference workshop with a training specialist. She informed me immediately that the job of reference in archives, as she was coming to understand it, was that of a consultant. This was news to me. But as I considered it, I realized that consultants conduct an interview to determine a client's need and the parameters of the search, evaluate available sources, and report their analysis to the client. I had always known colleagues who used their appraisal or arrangement and description expertise to become consulting archivists. But, to me, experts were the people who entered my reading room, already steeped in the knowledge of their subject area and wondering what gems I might be hiding in my collections.

Whether I'm working with the world-famous scholar, the in-house administrator, or the undergraduate, I remind myself that, in this consulting interaction, their expertise is either in their subject or in their understanding of the product they are seeking to create (book, report, term paper). I am the resident expert in the knowledge of my collections, in my ability to educate them about how to gain access to them through catalogs, finding aids, subject guides, and so on, and in my familiarity with primary sources and the best ways to find and contextualize them.

The urge to replace this consultancy with so-called expert systems is strong. But, to get the most out of our collections, I maintain that interaction with the reference staff, not just the completion of an online questionnaire, will always be a necessary component of a successful research encounter in an archives. Researchers benefit from our knowledge of the entirety of our holdings, the strengths and weaknesses of certain collections, what's new, and information about related collections else-where—in other words, our expertise. Even with all the tools available, connecting particular researchers with particular sources is still a common practice. I often feel like a matchmaker when I encourage a researcher to look at a certain collection or type of collection (“No really—you'll love it!”).

Recently a visiting scholar spent a week in our reading room, examining the transcripts of an early twentieth-century murder trial. The issue behind the murder was housing integration, and the question at hand was the character of the neighborhood in transition. The scholar was well versed in the uses of all the technology at our

disposal and made maximum use of all the guides and catalogs I showed to him. However, in conversation, I realized that he was unfamiliar with fire insurance maps, which show the layout of residential areas such as his neighborhood. Nothing in the catalog or finding aids would have led him to this source as it wouldn't be indexed by any subject headings meaningful to him. It was our mutual research partnership—or my mediation, if you prefer—that encouraged him to search this source. Page 41 → My broader knowledge of the range and nature of the sources at our disposal, and his knowledge of how to apply them to his own hypotheses, has led him to challenge widely held beliefs about the ethnicity and geography of the neighborhood in which the murder occurred.

Connecting mediation with consulting brings us to the concept of research strategy. This is the product that results from the consultancy. We can't hope to connect researchers with every document, let alone every collection that would be of use to them. But we can teach them how to use our tools, and, after listening carefully to their questions and needs, we can advise them about how best to approach our repository. We convey collection strengths, useful guides, ways to plan their time in view of offsite storage, size, and complexity of collections, and what to do about access restrictions. In addition, we understand local or institutional history or have general subject knowledge with which we can make connections they couldn't make as quickly, or perhaps at all.

Two final roles of the reference archivist are student and advocate. The student role is obvious: we learn every day from our researchers about the depth and breadth of our collections, but also about their potential uses and the types of documentation that current research demands. Especially this latter information informs a different type of mediation or “inreach” between the researcher and the rest of the archival staff: what are use trends, how are tools working, what are researchers looking for, what should we be collecting?

Unmediated Use, or Caught in the Web

I have alluded several times to mediation in the online environment. The exponential growth of e-mail research requests makes this continually more obvious. Though they often are phrased less elegantly or completely, the nature of e-mail communication allows us truly to converse about points of access, collection recommendations, or referrals in ways traditional correspondence made cumbersome. The sort of research partnership referred to earlier in this essay now often starts with an e-mail inquiry, a back and forth clarification of the request, a referral to guidelines posted on a Web page, and a better prepared researcher arriving at our door. Web sites, too, allow us to mount information that is easy to download and ponder on a researcher's own timetable. We can also include explanations, or translations, of our terminology and structure for those who choose to learn about it in this way. Think of it as self-paced Berlitz at home.

A more difficult situation concerns the use of electronic records, which never actually enter the repository but are managed by the archives via the records' office of origin. These postcustodial archives certainly will encourage unmediated use. On the other hand, making these records available will require that we produce some sort of digital mediation, or front end, to connect users with the record groups not in the archives' domain. Yakel reminds us that reference archivists often act as a filter.[15] She writes, “The archival challenge on the web becomes one of establishing a container [mechanism] that preserves or represents the evidence of the record while making explicit the thought process often involved in mediating between documents and users: *translating the user's subject-based question into a provenance-based system”* [my emphasis].[16] Certainly researchers have bypassed the reference staff for years, dismissing us with a click, declining to enter the research partnership, and navigating on their own. This may be more appealing or widespread via the Internet. The research partnership we offer is a value added aspect of archival service, not a requirement.

Conclusion

I agree with my colleagues that the concept of agency and involvement, with both the records and the researchers, is one that is rarely considered. Like all service professionals, our values tell us that good service is invisible, not obtrusive. This, however, fails to acknowledge the significant roles we play in connecting researchers and records, and especially in producing and explaining the tools we create to facilitate this process. My own observation of

interactions in the reference room indicate that many of us are so frustrated with our lack of influence in the research process that we withdraw behind a wall of bureaucracy and alienation from our researchers. Thinking instead of the ways in which we already shape the archives experience—and then working to improve them—will not only enhance our researchers' work lives but remind us of our own contributions to the research partnership.

NOTES

1. These quotes are found in the seminar presentation of Ann L. Stoler, “Colonial Archives and the Arts of Governance: On the Content in the Form,” in *Refiguring the Archive*, Carolyn Hamilton, ed. (Dordrecht: Kluwer), 2003. Sadly, Stoler Page 42 → and others equate the contents of the archives, influenced as they always will be by the availability of documentation—and of simple societal realities such as the inability of many historical subjects to write or leave documentation behind—with the institution of the archives. She thus confuses the archives—the repository in which these records rest and are, one hopes, now made generally accessible—with the intent of the original records creators and keepers of the documents
2. “Mediation is the Message: An Archival Challenge for the 21st Century,” *Archival Issues* 24:2 (1999), 111. Also, Nancy Bartlett, “Past Imperfect (*l'imparfait*): Mediating Meaning in Archives of Art,” this volume.
3. Paul Conway, “Partners in Research: Improving Access to the Nation's Archive/User Studies at the National Archives and Records Administration.” Pittsburgh: Archives and Museum Informatics, 1994. It was in Conway's publication that I first encountered the very apt and useful concept of this partnership.
4. Elizabeth Yakel, “Thinking Inside and Outside the Boxes: Archival Reference Services at the Close of the Twentieth Century,” *Archivaria*, no. 49 (Spring 2000), 140—60, see p. 151.
5. Blouin, unpublished opening remarks for Sawyer Seminar, Ann Arbor, Michigan, 2000.
6. Conversation with Joel Wurl, 1999.
7. In a recent e-mail query, a researcher referred to herself as “net stupid.” This apology seemed as important to her as her factual request.
8. Helen Willa Samuels. I am not aware that this was a published paper, but it was the title of many articles she wrote for various newsletters encouraging potential users of the Institute Archives, Massachusetts Institute of Technology.
9. Available online at: http://www.library.yale.edu/mssa/tutorial/tutorial.htm
10. Yakel, “Thinking Inside and Outside the Boxes,” 153.
11. For this wonderful turn of phrase, I am indebted to many conversations on this topic with Mary Jo Pugh, former reference archivist at the Bentley Historical Library.
12. Blouin, unpublished remarks for Sawyer Seminar..
13. Society of American Archivists, Code of Ethics, adopted 1992, also available at http://www.archivists.org/governance/handbook/app_ethics.asp
14. Yakel, “Thinking Inside and Outside the Boxes,” 153.
15. Ibid., 143.
16. Ibid., 150. The earliest articulation of this concept is, of course, Pugh's “The Illusion of Omniscience: Subject Access and the Reference Archivist,” *American Archivist* 45:1 (1982).